

Perth high schools, **made simple**

Where your child goes for high school shapes the next six years and a lot of what comes after. Here is exactly how the system works, what the different schools really offer, and the three ways in, in plain English.

WHERE YOU START

Every address is zoned to a **local public high school** you're guaranteed a spot at, no test, no early application. Most Lathlain families are zoned for schools like **Kent Street SHS**, **Belmont City College**, **Como Secondary** or **Cannington Community College**, though it varies by street and a few other things, so it's always worth confirming yours.

Want a public school you're *not* zoned for? You can still apply if there's room, with priority going to specialist-program students, then siblings, then whoever lives closest. The rest of this guide is about the options beyond your default.

WHAT YOU'RE REALLY CHOOSING

Why parents reach for a selective or private school

It comes down to a handful of things that shape a child's six years of high school, and much of what follows:

- 1 A higher-quality peer group**
These schools draw together students and families who place a high value on academics, so a culture of effort and ambition becomes the norm rather than the exception. By choosing where to apply, you also have some influence over the peers your child spends six years alongside.
- 2 Hand-picked, experienced teachers**
Private schools recruit and select their own teaching staff directly, so they can choose the people they regard as the strongest. Public schools have traditionally had less control over staffing, with teachers allocated through a central system. The result at many private schools is experienced staff who know your child by name and push them to do their best.
- 3 People whose job is your child's future**
Private schools fund dedicated specialist roles, careers counsellors, university and scholarship advisers, that public schools rarely can. Combined with programs like the Duke of Edinburgh Award, volunteering and structured co-curriculars, this gives your child genuine support to reach wherever they are aiming.
- 4 Clubs that help them find their direction**
Chess, coding, debating, mock trial, robotics, drama, music, sport and much more. Exploring a wide range is how a child discovers what they enjoy and where their strengths lie, which helps them shape a clearer sense of their future.
- 5 Opportunities, constantly**
Public schools offer opportunities too, but private schools tend to offer more of them, more often: Model UN, overseas exchanges, academic and sporting competitions, workshops, guest talks, career evenings with professionals from medicine, law and engineering, alongside the social side such as formals and balls.
- 6 Facilities & a powerful community**
This is one of the clearest advantages. More money flows into private schools, so they tend to have better and more extensive facilities, pools, gyms, studios, theatres and laboratories, which open up far more ways for your child to spend their time. You also join a community that includes many of the state's most established and well-connected families.

How much of each of these a school offers **differs from school to school**, and not only between public, selective and private. The differences run deep even within those groups, as the comparison later in this guide shows.

Three doors into a better school

There are three ways to land your child somewhere *other than your default*. Two involve a test; one doesn't. It often pays to line up a few of these at once, so you're not relying on a single result.

DOOR 1 · FREE

Selective public

No fees. Entry by one test.

Perth Modern is fully selective: it makes offers to the highest-scoring students who list it among their preferences, working down from the top until its places are filled. **Rossmoyne, Willetton, Shenton** and others run selective academic programs you can only enter through the GATE test, open to students **from outside their catchment**, so you are not limited to where you live.

HOW IT WORKS

1. Register your child for the **GATE / ASET test** (one online application).
2. They sit one exam, in Year 6, Term 1.
3. Roughly the top quarter of scorers are offered a place. No interview.

DOOR 2 · SCHOLARSHIP

Prestige private, skip the line

Fees, cut 25–75% by scholarship.

The top-reputation boys' (**PSA**) and girls' (**IGSSA**) schools, for example Hale, Christ Church, Scotch, St Hilda's, MLC and Penrhos. Their waitlists can be very long, and without family or existing ties to the school it's often hard to get a spot if you haven't joined early. By Year 5 a **scholarship is frequently the only way in**. That said, waitlist lengths shift and no one really knows, so if you want a place, still join the waitlist too.

HOW IT WORKS

1. Apply to each school and register for its **scholarship exam**.
2. Your child sits the test, which is usually shared with several "partner schools", so one exam can put them in front of a few schools at once.
3. Top scorers are **interviewed**, then offered a scholarship and place. Some schools also offer sport or music scholarships.

Realistically: these are often harder to win than a GATE/ASET place. A school may award only a few academic scholarships a year, and some of those go to students already enrolled. That is exactly why preparation counts.

DOOR 3 · JUST APPLY

Other private schools

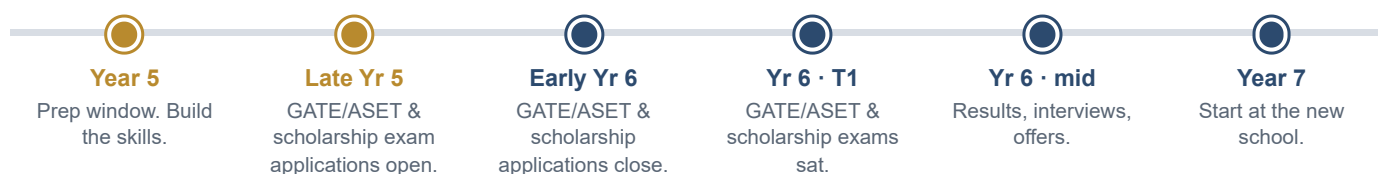
Fees, lower at many Catholic schools.

Plenty of strong independent and Catholic schools sit outside the PSA/IGSSA circle, for example **John XXIII, Ursula Frayne, Mercy, Aranmore** and **Newman**, alongside Christian and Montessori schools. Many of the same benefits apply, and the offering differs widely from school to school.

HOW IT WORKS

1. You usually **just apply**, often with no entrance test.
2. Requirements differ widely: some have waitlists, some don't.
3. Scholarships vary too, some by an entrance exam, some means-tested.

THE TIMELINE FOR A CHILD IN YEAR 5 THIS YEAR



The strategy: have a few options lined up

You essentially get **one shot** at the main Year 7 intake. These are high-pressure tests, and a single bad day or some bad luck can mean missing out on a school your child was well capable of. With GATE/ASET you already list several preferences, so the real move is to also **line up a few private and scholarship schools**, so that if things go badly you still land somewhere you're happy with. What "happy" looks like differs for every family, which is something I'm glad to help you think through. Later entry points exist but have far fewer places, so the Year 7 round is the one to take seriously.

THE ACRONYMS

GATE / ASET — the one test for free selective public schools. GATE stands for Gifted and Talented Education (the older name); ASET for the Academic Selective Entrance Test (the current name).

PSA — the prestige independent boys' schools.

ATAR — the Year 12 ranking used for university entry.

AAS & ACER — the two companies that write private scholarship exams. Scores don't transfer between them.

IGSSA — the prestige independent girls' schools.

Local intake area — your catchment: the public school your address is guaranteed into.

The kinds of school, side by side

PSA and IGSSA schools have the top reputation for good reason, but reputation doesn't mean they're the right school for *your* child and goals. Here's the honest comparison.

	Local public	Selective public	PSA / IGSSA	Other private
Fees	Free	Free	Highest, scholarships cut them	Lower
Academic strength	Mixed	Perth Mod strong, others vary	Strong	Varies
Hand-picked teachers	No	No	Yes, schools choose their staff	Varies
Support to reach uni / overseas	Standard	Good	Extensive, individual	Varies
Clubs & co-curriculars	Varies	Good	Very broad	Good, varies
Facilities (pools, theatres, labs)	Varies	Good	Typically the best	Good, varies
Career nights & connections	Limited	Some	Strong	Some, varies
Co-ed or single-sex	Co-ed	Co-ed	Single-sex	Mostly co-ed
How you get in	Live in zone	GATE/ASET score	Apply early &/or scholarship exam	Varies, often just apply

Important: the level of every one of these differs within each group, so this is only a quick orientation, not the full story. Choosing well means looking closely at individual schools, which is exactly the kind of thing I can help you do.

WANT TO LOOK AROUND YOURSELF?

A few good starting points: myschool.edu.au for per-school stats, bettereducation.com.au for ATAR rankings, and each school's own website for subjects and overall outcomes in previous years. Open days are free and the best way to get a real feel for a place.

It can get a bit dense. If you'd rather not wade through it, I'm happy to talk through what matters for your child.

25–75% off

Typical academic scholarship, every year for six years of school

A top PSA or IGSSA school runs to roughly **\$30,000 a year or more** in tuition. On a \$30,000 fee, a **75% scholarship saves about \$135,000** across six years of high school, and even a quarter off is around **\$45,000**. A scholarship rarely covers everything, but it can bring a school you would otherwise rule out on cost within reach. The selective public route, of course, removes fees altogether.

WHERE THIS LANDS

For a lot of families, once it's all laid out, the move is to prep for these tests.

The better peer group, the teachers, the clubs, the support and the opportunities, that's what a selective or private school can give your child. The catch is that the doors only open through tests sat in early Year 6, with the real work done in Year 5, and you get just one good shot at the main intake. **Understand how it all works, and you can work towards getting into where you actually want to go, instead of leaving the decision to be made for you.**

WHERE I FIT IN

Map your options

A clear shortlist of selective and private schools that suit your child and your goals.

Prepare for the tests

Focused GATE/ASET and scholarship-exam preparation, built around your child.

Plan the timing

Which applications open and close when, so nothing is missed.

If anything here doesn't make sense, call me.

I'd be more than happy to help you choose your child's dream high school and get them into it, in line with your goals and hopes for their uni, work and life ahead. If you want to understand how ATAR works, how UniReady works, or which schools and scholarships suit your child, it's always better to know earlier than later. Give me a call anytime, no pressure at all.

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